While unanimity ensures that every member has an equal voice, it also risks paralysis when consensus cannot be achieved. For example, the EU's requirement for unanimity on foreign policy decisions has frequently led to deadlock, with individual member states wielding veto power to block collective action. The same goes for the passage of sweeping trade legislation at the WTO. Such rigidity can make it exceedingly difficult to implement appeasement or sidelining strategies, especially when such measures require formal votes on contentious issues like restructuring voting shares or imposing conditionality. Conversely, certain actions, such as informal information-sharing agreements or administrative reforms, may bypass these constraints and be executed directly by bureaucrats or institutional leaders.

Other IOs employ supermajority or qualified majority voting systems, which balance inclusivity with the need for efficiency. For instance, the UN General Assembly requires a two-thirds majority for key decisions, while the IMF employs weighted voting that reflects member states' financial contributions. These systems can accelerate decision making compared with unanimity but may also amplify the influence of powerful states. This dynamic can complicate efforts to address populism if influential populist leaders use their weighted votes to stall or derail initiatives. On the flip side, countries with limited vote share may find themselves marginalized, which populist leaders can exploit to rally domestic opposition by claiming their voices are ignored.

Rotational voting systems and leadership structures provide another avenue for decision making. For example, the UN Security Council's rotation of nonpermanent members allows different states temporary influence in shaping policies. While this ensures a degree of equity and inclusivity, it can create inconsistencies in how IOs address populist challenges, as leadership priorities shift over time. Conversely, centralized decision making vested in a secretariat or director general, as seen in the WTO and some UN agencies, can enable swifter responses to crises. However, this concentration of power may also draw populist criticism, reinforcing claims that IOs are run by unaccountable elites.

Rigid decision-making frameworks, particularly those requiring unanimity, often leave IOs struggling to respond effectively to populist threats. The EU exemplifies this challenge—its governance structure is